



Appeal for Reconsideration of Hatkanangale-Ichalkaranji New Line Project on Socio-Economic Grounds despite negative ROR (-12.73%)

1 message

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Wed, 27 May, 2026 at 7:08 pm

Respected Sir/Madam,

This is with reference to the recent clarifications received through RTI and Grievance Portals stating that the proposed Hatkanangale-Ichalkaranji New Railway Line Project (Approx. 8 km) has a negative Rate of Return (ROR) of -12.73%, making it financially unviable as per standard norms.

While we understand the financial constraints based on conventional traffic surveys, we earnestly appeal to the Railway Board to reconsider this crucial project under the special "Socio-Economic Development" and "PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan" guidelines, due to the following vital reasons:
Underestimation of Freight Potential: Ichalkaranji is the 'Manchester of Maharashtra' with an annual textile turnover exceeding ₹15,000 to ₹20,000 Crores. The city produces nearly 2 Crore meters of cloth daily. The current ROR survey seems to have under-calculated the massive outward freight traffic (yarn, fabric, and garments) that currently relies entirely on road transport to destinations like Surat, Ahmedabad, and Mumbai.

Exemption on Socio-Economic Grounds: As per the Ministry of Railways' historic precedents, projects connecting major industrial, textile, or backward clusters can be sanctioned on socio-economic grounds, even if they do not meet the standard positive ROR criteria (min +10% to +12%).

Massive Passenger Demand: Over 3 Lakh workers, traders, and daily commuters travel in and out of Ichalkaranji. Direct rail connectivity will provide safe, affordable, and rapid transit, heavily boosting regional economic integration.
Call for State Partnership (Cost-Sharing Model): If financial viability remains a constraint, we urge the Railway Board to formally initiate a dialogue with the Government of Maharashtra for a 50:50 Cost-Sharing Model along with free land acquisition, similar to other successful joint-venture rail projects in the state.

An 8 km connection is a very small infrastructure investment for the Indian Railways, but it holds the potential to transform the textile economy of Western Maharashtra and generate huge long-term freight revenue.

We request you to please order a fresh techno-economic survey or review this project through the lens of industrial cargo potential rather than just passenger traffic.

Thank you.
Awaiting your positive intervention